expansion of the U.S. empire around the world and a redeployment of cultural fears of a communist threat barely tempered by occasional calls to thaw relations between the United States and the USSR.[22]

The second current that set the stage for Reagan's rhetoric was the boom in memorial culture. Political struggles of the Cold War were publicly routed through debates about "sites of memory" and questioned legacies of World War II freedom and repression. Pierre Nora's landmark essay "Between Memory and History: Les Lieux de Mémoire" (published in French in 1984 and translated into English in 1989) identifies "sites of memory" at odds with "real memory." In some cases, such sites are where "hopelessly forgetful modern societies … organize the past," yet for Nora, "sites of memory" also beckon the potential for a cultural memory that approaches "critical history."[23] Spikes in contested national expressions of cultural memory were also fueled, in part, by increased economic and social rootlessness, amidst swirling questions and debates about national identity, impacted by race, gender, sexuality, and class. Marita Sturken writes, "Cultural memory is a means through which definitions of the nation and 'Americanness' are simultaneously established, questioned, and reconfigured." Sturken discusses official memorial projects as measures to bring "cohesion" and "closure," as opposed to cultural memory, which seeks to democratize modes of historical representation and reflection.[24] Given Reagan's rhetoric at Bitburg, especially his "I am a Berliner" remarks, his overlapping memorializing and Cold War strategic alliance missions become clear. He laid bare a U.S. agenda that sought to rescript national identity along the imperatives of rollback foreign policy, in this instance by routing a global American identity through Germany and the transnational cultural imaginary of the Berlin Wall.

Reagan was not alone in testing the expressive boundaries of Cold War rhetoric and policy. As discussed previously, American artists and writers had explored the Cold War "borderlands" of Berlin since 1961 to make sense of U.S. Cold War policy as well as to test the limits of American identity. Joyce Carol Oates's collection of short stories *Last Days* (1984) was inspired in part by her 1980 trip to Berlin. Oates writes about Cold War division along the Iron Curtain in stories about Germany, Poland, and North Africa, among other locales. Two of her stories, "Ich bin ein Berliner" and "Our Wall," take place on opposite sides of the divided city. In Oates's journals from the period of her own trip, she reports she was "haunted" by the Berlin